

The Swan Children's Lullaby

The emerald isles of the Celts roll green and misty between a silver sea and soft grey skies, dotted with thatched roundhouses, ancient oak groves, and rings of humming standing stones. Mist drifts over still lochs, and across it, just out of sight, lies the Land of Youth where no one grows old. The isles are full of gentle wonders: a playful shapeshifting faerie, a wise old salmon, a shy selkie of the loch, and four children long ago turned into singing swans. Here a hero is not the strongest or the loudest, but the one who is clever, listens kindly, and keeps a promise. The grandest deeds are done with cleverness and courage and a kind heart, and even a fearsome-seeming stranger, met with a friendly word, often turns out lonelier than it is unkind.



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Read aloud, slowly and warmly. Stop often to let the children answer. There are no wrong answers here, only brave new ideas to try.

Before you begin

Every dusk, four white swans sing a little song over the Misty Loch. Their lullaby lifts the mist and paints the sky rose and gold. But tonight the song goes wobbly. It forgets its tune. A sad grey mist settles over the loch and over the whole village, and nobody can see the sunset.

Old Maeve the Tale-Weaver calls you to her by the warm hearth. "You two have clever heads and kind hearts," she says. "Will you help the swan children remember their lullaby, so the mist lifts again?"

She gives you three gifts: the little harp, a sprig of oak, and a honey oatcake. Then she smiles. "Here we do not win by being the strongest. We win by being clever, brave, and kind."

What is your hero name? Are you a hero of Cleverness, of Courage, or of Kindness?

Stop 1: The Grey Mist



You walk down to the loch. The grey mist is so thick you can barely see the water. Somewhere out there are the four swan children, but they are quiet and hidden.

How will you find them? Could you stand very still and listen? Could you call out softly and kindly, so you do not frighten them? Try something and see.

When you draw near, gently and kindly, four white shapes glide out of the mist. Four swans with soft, sad eyes. They are pleased to see a kind face. They let you come close.

Stop 2: Remembering the Lullaby



The swan children want to sing, but they have forgotten their lullaby. The words have all jumbled up. Three little verses float in the mist, out of order, and the song will not work until they go back the right way.

Pook the Puca, a playful faerie, peeks out of an oak and gives you a wink and a hint.

Can you help them put the lullaby back together? Listen to each verse. Which one comes first? Which one comes last? You can talk it through together.

When you set the three verses in the right order, the swan children's eyes light up. "That is it!" they whisper. "That is how it goes!"

Stop 3: Playing It Together



The swan children know the words now, but they are shy. One little swan is the shyest of all. She opens her beak, and no sound comes out. She tucks her head under her wing.

This is not a fight. How could you help her feel brave? You have the little harp. Could you play a gentle tune for them all? Could you tell the shy swan she is not alone, and sing along so she does not sing by herself?

When you play the little harp and sing with them, the shyest swan lifts her head. A small, sweet note slips out. Then another. Soon all four are singing together, strong and clear.

The Dusk Turns Rose



The lullaby rises over the Misty Loch, just as it used to. The grey mist softens and thins. It melts away into rose and gold, and the sunset pours over the water.

Up on the green rise, the Ring of Standing Stones hums along, low and happy. The swan children glide in a circle, singing their hearts out. And high above the loch, Danu the Kind looks down and smiles at you.

You did it together. You were clever, you were brave, and most of all, you were kind. Goodnight, heroes. Sweet dreams.

My Adventure Sheet

Draw your hero

My name

I am a hero of

My energy stars (colour one in when you spend it)



My magics



My magic is

It can



My magic is

It can



My magic is

It can

What I carry

Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.

Wits and Wonder

Story Pack

<https://github.com/agigante80/wits-and-wonder>

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Version 1.3, updated 2026-06-04, en-GB



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